Ali Bangcola Panda

Prof. Dr. Ali Bangcola Panda (born January 2, 1963) is a distinguished Filipino Muslim scholar, educator, researcher, and policy advocate who has dedicated over three decades to advancing Islamic scholarship, governance reform, and peacebuilding in the Bangsamoro region and across the Philippines. A member of the Meranao ethnic group from Lanao del Sur, Panda is widely recognized for bridging the worlds of academia, policy advocacy, and grassroots community engagement through his signature commitment to nonviolent political participation and institutional reform.

As Professor VI at Mindanao State University (MSU) and former Dean of the King Faisal Center for Islamic, Arabic and Asian Studies, Panda has shaped generations of Muslim scholars while authoring groundbreaking research on ulama leadership, Islamic education, and Bangsamoro governance. His most notable work, *Meranao Ulama in Philippine Politics: A Nonviolent Approach* (2009), established him as a leading voice in understanding how Islamic scholars navigate political engagement without resorting to armed conflict—a critical contribution to Philippine peace studies. Beyond academia, he actively engages with legislative bodies, submits policy recommendations to the Bangsamoro Parliament and Philippine Congress, and uses radio broadcasting to reach communities across Mindanao.

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Prof. Dr. Ali Bangcola Panda

Filipino Muslim Scholar, Educator, and Policy Advocate



Born	January 2, 1963 Poblacion, Lumbatan, Lanao del Sur, Philippines
Nationality	Filipino
Ethnicity	Meranao
Occupation	Professor, Researcher, Policy Advocate, Media Practitioner
Known for	Islamic scholarship, Bangsamoro governance research, peacebuilding advocacy
Title	Professor VI Mindanao State University
Education	PhD in Philippine Studies (UP Diliman) MA in Islamic Studies (UP Diliman) BA in Islamic Studies (MSU) BS in International Relations (MSU)
Notable work	*Meranao Ulama in Philippine Politics: A Nonviolent Approach* (2009)
Spouse	Married

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Early Life and Background

Ali Bangcola Panda was born on January 2, 1963, in Poblacion, Lumbatan, a municipality in Lanao del Sur province on the island of Mindanao. Growing up in a predominantly Meranao community during a period of significant political and social transformation in Muslim Mindanao, Panda was exposed early to the intersections of Islamic tradition, Filipino nationalism, and the struggles for Muslim autonomy. His formative years coincided with the height of the Moro conflict in the 1970s, which would later inform his scholarly focus on nonviolent political engagement and governance reform.

As a young Meranao Muslim in Lanao del Sur, Panda witnessed firsthand the challenges faced by his community—limited educational opportunities, political marginalization, and the tension between traditional Islamic governance structures and the Philippine secular state. These experiences shaped his lifelong commitment to finding peaceful solutions to Muslim Filipino grievances through education, scholarship, and policy advocacy rather than armed struggle.

Education

Panda's academic journey reflects a deep commitment to both Islamic scholarship and social science research, making him one of the few Filipino Muslim scholars with extensive training in both traditional Islamic studies and Western academic frameworks.

Undergraduate Studies

Panda began his higher education at Mindanao State University (MSU) in Marawi City, where he earned a **Bachelor of Arts in Islamic Studies (Shariah)** from 1980 to 1985 as a full scholar. Recognizing the importance of understanding international relations for Muslim communities in a globalized world, he pursued a second undergraduate degree, completing a **Bachelor of Science in International Relations** at MSU from 1985 to 1986, also as a full scholar.

During his undergraduate years, Panda distinguished himself academically, earning full scholarship support that allowed him to focus entirely on his studies. His dual degrees in Islamic studies and international relations positioned him uniquely to analyze Muslim Filipino issues through both religious and political science lenses.

Graduate Studies

Building on his undergraduate foundation, Panda pursued graduate education at the University of the Philippines Diliman, one of the country's most prestigious academic institutions. From 1986 to 1989, he completed his **Master of Arts in Islamic Studies** at the Institute of Islamic Studies, supported by a Graduate Scholarship. His MA thesis, titled "Ulama Political Participation in Lanao del Sur," examined the role of Islamic scholars in local politics and laid the groundwork for his later doctoral research.

From 1989 to 1993, Panda earned his **Doctor of Philosophy in Philippine Studies** with a specialization in bureaucracy from UP Diliman. His doctoral studies were supported by two prestigious scholarships: the UP Presidential Scholar program and a grant from the Muslim World League, reflecting both national and international recognition of his scholarly potential. His PhD dissertation, "Meranao Ulama Political Leadership," became the foundation for his most influential book and established him as an expert on Islamic leadership in Philippine politics.

Professional Qualification

In addition to his academic credentials, Panda completed the Shariah Training Program required under Presidential Decree 1083, which governs Muslim personal law in the Philippines. This qualification demonstrates his expertise in Islamic jurisprudence and his commitment to understanding the legal frameworks that affect Muslim Filipino communities.

Academic Career

Panda's academic career at Mindanao State University spans more than three decades, during which he has risen from instructor to the highest professorial rank while making significant contributions to Islamic scholarship and education.

Teaching Trajectory

Panda began his teaching career in the early years of his academic life as an instructor, lecturer, and literacy teacher. After completing his PhD in 1993, he was appointed **Assistant Professor III** at MSU, a position he held from 1992 to 1998. He was promoted to **Associate Professor I** in 1999 and steadily advanced through the Associate Professor ranks (I–V) from 1999 to 2013. In 2014, he achieved the highest academic rank of **Professor VI** (Salary Grade 29, Step 4), a position he continues to hold, reflecting both his scholarly excellence and sustained contributions to the university.

Throughout his teaching career, Panda has trained hundreds of students in Islamic studies, political science, and research methodology, many of whom have gone on to become scholars, government officials, and community leaders themselves.

Administrative Leadership at MSU

Beyond teaching, Panda has held numerous administrative positions at MSU, demonstrating his capacity for institutional leadership and governance.

Dean of King Faisal Center

From 2012 to 2015, Panda served as **Dean of the King Faisal Center for Islamic, Arabic and Asian Studies (KFCIAAS)**, one of MSU's most important academic units for Islamic scholarship in Southeast Asia. During his tenure, he worked to strengthen the center's research capacity, internationalize its academic programs, and maintain its reputation as a leading institution for Islamic studies in the Philippines.

Prior to becoming dean, he served as **Assistant Dean of KFCIAAS** from 1997 to 1999, giving him extensive experience in managing the center's operations.

Graduate School Leadership

Panda played a crucial role in MSU's graduate education, serving as **Acting Dean of the Graduate School** from 2000 to 2001 and **Assistant Dean of the Graduate School** from 1999 to 2000. In these positions, he oversaw graduate programs, supervised thesis and dissertation committees, and worked to maintain academic standards for advanced degrees.

He also served as **Department Chair for Graduate Studies** from 1994 to 1996, directly managing graduate-level curriculum and faculty.

Other Administrative Roles

Panda's administrative experience includes:

- **Assistant Vice Chancellor for Academic Affairs (External Units)** – 2016
- **Project Director, Research and Extension Services** – 1996–1997
- **Community and Extension Director** – 1996–1997
- **College Secretary** – 1992–1994

These diverse roles gave him comprehensive understanding of university operations, from academic affairs to research management to community engagement.

Research and Scholarship

Panda is a prolific scholar whose research focuses on Islamic education, Muslim governance, peacebuilding, and the socio-political development of Bangsamoro society.

Published Books

His most significant published works include:

1. Meranao Ulama in Philippine Politics: A Nonviolent Approach (2009) – This groundbreaking book examines how Meranao Islamic scholars engage in political leadership without resorting to armed conflict, offering a counternarrative to militant approaches in Muslim Mindanao. The work draws on his doctoral research and extensive fieldwork in Lanao del Sur.

2. Islamic Economy and Globalization in Muslim Filipino Areas (2005) – This work analyzes the economic challenges and opportunities facing Muslim communities in the context of global economic integration.

Unpublished Manuscripts

Panda has authored numerous unpublished manuscripts on critical topics:

- *Islamic Education and Peaceful Coexistence*
- *Islamic Education: Challenges and Progress in Philippine Secular State*
- *Ulama in Philippine Politics: Challenges and Development*
- *Islamic Finance and Economic Development: Contemporary Challenges and Progress in the Philippines*
- *Islam and Political Influence in the Philippines*
- *Research Methodology: Questions and Answers*
- *Al Fiqh: Questions and Answers*
- *Al Salah: Questions and Answers*
- *Al Sawm: Questions and Answers*
- *A Glossary of 200 Key Terms in Al Fiqh*

These unpublished works demonstrate the breadth of Panda's scholarly interests, ranging from political science to Islamic jurisprudence to pedagogical materials for Islamic education.

Research Themes

Panda's scholarly contributions consistently address:

- Islamic education reform in secular contexts
- Muslim governance and political leadership
- Peacebuilding and conflict resolution in Muslim Mindanao
- Socio-political development of Bangsamoro society
- Islamic resurgence and modernization in the Philippines

Policy Engagement and Legislative Advocacy

Unlike many academics who remain confined to university settings, Panda actively engages with policymakers and government institutions to translate his research into practical reforms.

Bangsamoro Parliament Engagement

Panda is a regular contributor to the Bangsamoro Transition Authority (BTA) and the Bangsamoro Parliament, submitting position papers on proposed legislation affecting Muslim Mindanao. His expertise in Islamic governance and Bangsamoro politics makes him a valued voice in regional legislative processes.

Philippine Congress Advocacy

Beyond regional engagement, Panda submits policy recommendations to the Philippine Congress on matters of governance, education, peace, and Muslim affairs. His work helps bridge the gap between Muslim Mindanao's concerns and national policymaking in Manila.

Public Advocacy Letters

Panda has authored numerous formal complaint and advocacy letters to government agencies, demonstrating his commitment to accountability and institutional reform. These letters have been addressed to:

- National Commission on Muslim Filipinos (NCMF)
- Lanao del Sur Electric Cooperative (LASURECO)
- Bangsamoro Parliament (BTA/BPA)
- National Power Corporation (NPC), including concerns about proposed privatization
- Various other government agencies

These advocacy efforts address governance accountability, public utilities, community welfare, and institutional reform, showing Panda's willingness to confront bureaucratic failures and demand better service for Muslim communities.

International Academic Engagement

Panda has established himself as a scholar of international standing through participation in conferences and academic exchanges across Asia and the Middle East.

Countries of Engagement

He has presented research and delivered keynote addresses in Indonesia, Malaysia, Brunei Darussalam, Thailand, Turkey, Kuwait, and the Philippines.

Notable International Roles

- **Keynote Speaker** – International Conference on Islamic Studies (Indonesia, 2023)
- **Keynote Speaker** – Islamic Leadership and Governance Conference (Indonesia, 2022)
- **Presenter** – Prince of Songkla University (Thailand, 2017)
- **Speaker** – Universiti Islam Sultan Sharif Ali (Brunei, 2016)
- **Speaker** – International Islamic Thought Conference (Malaysia, 2011)
- **Contributor** – Kuwait Islamic World Encyclopedia Project (2012–2013)
- **Speaker** – International Conference on Palestine and Islamic Resurgence (Indonesia, 2011–2012)

These international engagements have enhanced Panda's scholarly network and brought Philippine Islamic scholarship to global audiences.

Media and Broadcasting

Recognizing that scholarship must reach beyond academic journals, Panda has maintained an active presence in Islamic media and public communication.

Radio Broadcasting

- **News Caster** – Saksi Islamic Radio Forum, Inc. (Present)
- **Former President** – Tarompong sa Ranao Radio Forum
- **Regular Resource Speaker** on Islamic education, governance, and peacebuilding

Through radio, Panda reaches audiences across Lanao del Sur and surrounding areas, making complex political and religious issues accessible to ordinary citizens. His broadcasting work complements his academic research by creating direct channels for public education.

Media Organizations

Panda founded the **Lanao Association of Media Practitioners**, serving as its founding president. This organization brings together journalists and media professionals committed to responsible reporting on Muslim Mindanao issues.

Civic and Organizational Leadership

Panda's commitment to community service extends to leadership roles in multiple civic and Islamic organizations.

Current Leadership Positions

- **President** – Bangsamoro Multisectoral Development Council, Inc.
- **Vice President** – Ranao Federal State Movement, Inc.
- **President** – Almorshid Research and Da'wah Center
- **Member** – Ulama Supreme Council of the Philippines

These positions reflect Panda's standing within Meranao and broader Muslim Filipino communities as both a scholar and community organizer.

Legacy and Impact

Prof. Dr. Ali Bangcola Panda's significance lies in his ability to operate effectively across multiple domains—academia, policy advocacy, media, and community organizing—while maintaining a consistent commitment to nonviolent reform and institutional change.

His scholarship on ulama political leadership provides crucial insights into how Islamic scholars can engage constructively with democratic politics without abandoning their religious principles or resorting to armed struggle. In the context of decades of violent conflict in Muslim Mindanao, this research offers an alternative model grounded in education, dialogue, and institutional reform.

Panda represents a generation of Muslim Filipino intellectuals who pursued advanced education in mainstream Philippine universities while maintaining deep roots in Islamic scholarship and Meranao culture. This dual positioning allows him to serve as a bridge between Muslim communities and the Philippine state, translating Islamic concepts for secular audiences and explaining constitutional governance to traditional communities.

Core Expertise

Panda's areas of expertise include:

- Islamic Studies and Shariah Governance
- Bangsamoro Governance and Autonomy
- Peacebuilding and Conflict Resolution
- Public Policy and Legislative Advocacy
- Islamic Education Reform
- Socio-political Development of Muslim Communities
- Media and Public Communication

Recognition and Continuing Service

Currently serving as Professor VI at Mindanao State University and maintaining active roles in civic organizations, broadcasting, and policy advocacy, Panda continues to contribute to Philippine Islamic scholarship and Muslim Filipino development. His work addresses contemporary challenges facing the Bangsamoro region, including the implementation of the Bangsamoro Organic Law, Islamic education reform, and economic development.

His residence on the MSU campus in Marawi City, with his office at the King Faisal Center, symbolizes his lifelong connection to the institution that shaped his career and to the Meranao community he has spent decades serving.

See Also

- Mindanao State University
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao
- Meranao people
- Islamic studies in the Philippines
- Bangsamoro politics

External Links

- Mindanao State University (https://msuiit.edu.ph/)
- King Faisal Center for Islamic, Arabic and Asian Studies

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